FROM THE

EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

The psychological hold Prime Minister Narendra Modi has on the Indian electorate is phenomenal. A full decade after he strode on to the national stage, he still walks like a colossus. In February 2024, a bare two months before the general election, an overwhelming 54.9 per cent endorse Modi's name when asked for the person best suited to be India's prime minister—a 2.6 percentage point rise over the 52.3 per cent he clocked in August 2023. And 60.5 per cent rate his prime ministerial performance as good or outstanding. A minor dip of 2.2 percentage points over August but, considering he is in the final year of his second term, more a high benchmark of inner buoyancy than anything else. The INDIA TODAY-CVoter Mood of the Nation (MOTN) survey has been tracking Indian politics for the past 20 years. Since Modi led the BJP to power in New Delhi with that stunning victory in 2014, the approval for his performance as prime minister in our bi-annual MOTNs has never dipped below 50 per cent, something that would be the envy of any leader in the world.

That dominance is reinforced by other crucial findings of the MOTN. Were a general election to be held now, the BJP alone would get 304 seats. That's one more than its tally in 2019 and, more importantly, 17 more than the August '23 figure—heralding a comfortable majority. The consecration of the Ram temple seems to have given them a lift as it marks the fulfilment of a long-gestating dream for the party. The BJP's vote share thus goes up to 39.6 per cent, from 37.7 per cent in August last year. The battery was nowhere close to running out, but has nevertheless received a surge of new voltage. That 2 percentage point recharge effect is spread right across. This results in the NDA's cumulative vote share going to 44.4 per cent and delivers the ruling alliance an overall tally of 335 seats—up from the 42.6 per cent and 306 seats registered in August.



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Politics is a zero sum game: one side's gain has to come at the other's cost. Back in August '23, the I.N.D.I.A. bloc was taking 193 seats—that has come down to 166. Bruised by the exit of Bihar chief minister Nitish Kumar and his party, its vote share has slipped from a creditable 41 per cent to 38.3 per cent. It is difficult for the Congress to match the perfect pairing of the charisma of Narendra Modi and the political astuteness of home minister Amit Shah. The vote share of the Congress, the main party in that alliance, exhibits a slide from 20.3 per cent to 18.9 per cent, with a commensurate drop in seats from 74 to 71. The personal popularity of its leader Rahul Gandhi, much trumpeted by the party machinery, does not yield a favourable picture among the INDIA TODAY-CVoter respondent base. Only 13.8 per cent judge him to be the best person for the PM's job. This presents a mammoth gap of 41 percentage points between Modi and him, and is below even the 15.8 per cent he registered in August '23. The Bharat Jodo Nyay Yatra, his present east-to-west expedition across India, does not seem to have created any boost for him or his party. There is no narrative from him or his party that has resonated with the electorate.

In contrast, an overwhelming 68.7 per cent believe the Ram temple is a great symbol of Hindu revival. And 42 per cent say Modi will be remembered for its construction. When asked for his biggest achievement, his handling of Covid still gets the highest number of tick marks at 20 per cent. But core Hindutva events like Ayodhya and the Kashi corridor have leapt up from a mere 10.7 per cent in August '23 to 16.9 per cent now—a clear sign that he has struck the right chord with the Hindu majority. This seems to rub off on associated figures. Yogi Adityanath has been rated as the best among India's 30 chief ministers eight times in a row. But the number of pan-India respondents who vote for the Uttar Pradesh CM has gone up from 43 per cent in August to 46 per cent now. And only one event has come in between: his presence, along with Modi, at the *pran pratishtha* ceremony. The next popular CM, Arvind Kejriwal, nets only 19.6 per cent votes. When it comes to popularity in their own home states, it's the redoubtable Naveen Patnaik, CM of Odisha, who remains number one—though dropping from 61.3 per cent to 52.7 per cent.

While the 'Ram recharge' helps boost the BJP, the Modi government's performance on the economic front remains mixed. Those who describe it as 'outstanding or good' still occupy the high ranges at 49.7 per cent—a clear endorsement of just how well Modi handled the deleterious impact of the Covid pandemic and steered the Indian economy to a solid recovery. With growth rates averaging 7 per cent and above in the past two years, India is now rated as one of the fastest-growing major economies in the world. But the MOTN results also brought out issues that remain a matter of concern for the electorate. When asked whether their own economic status had changed since Modi took charge as PM, 32.6 per cent say it has improved—a rise of three percentage points from six months ago. But those who say their status had remained the same or worsened remains a high 63.6 per cent. That is reinforced by another question on household income, where only 25.2 per cent of those surveyed believe it will get better. An improvement of three percentage points since August '23, it still left 65.9 per cent who believe it will remain the same or worsen. Those who say their current expenses have become difficult to manage continue to form a high 61.7 per cent. As many as 71 per cent tag unemployment as a major concern, with 53.8 per cent calling the situation "very serious". Importantly for Modi, even as people raise such worries, it has not impacted his poll numbers, as the majority believe he remains their best bet to resolve such issues.

Brand Modi is clearly not subject to voter fatigue and ennui the way political figures usually are. Take Rajiv Gandhi, for comparison. Forty years ago, he had come riding an even bigger tidal crest: 414 Lok Sabha seats. But Rajiv frittered that away in a matter of five years to come down to 197. Modi does not seem to come from a world where political brands are perishable commodities and give way to new generations and fresh ideas. After a decade in power, he is within clear sight of a peak only Rajiv's grandfather, Jawaharlal Nehru, has conquered before: a hat-trick as prime minister with a full majority.

(Aroon Purie)